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The Spirit of a Warrior

Certain aspects of one's psyche, culture and behaviour are innate reflections of one's upbringing and influences. 'Punjabiyat' and 'Sikhi' have been my heritage, bestowed on me by the collective consciousness of Sikhism. Having been brought up in the typically heterogeneous, secular and typified environs of army, I may not have been aware of it in a conscious manner in my early years. However, though I held dear the olive-green values as the greater cultural connect of my life, the tenets of my faith have been a guiding beacon during the journey.

In my childhood, every day at dusk, we used to surround our mother as she recited the Rehras Sahib, a prayer from our scriptures. We understood little, but by repeatedly listening to it, portions of this prayer got embedded in our minds. My Nanaji (maternal grandfather), a pious man, was in service as an office superintendant during the Raj period in Rawalpindi. One fine day he just resigned from his job, saying that he would from that moment onwards be in the service of Wahe Guru. At the time of Partition, he, along with his family, migrated to Patiala. In childhood we often spent our holidays with them. His letters to me, written in English, were very inspiring. When I was growing up, I recall that Nanaji, whom we used to respectfully address as Khalsaji, always encouraged me to speak in the gurdwara on occasions like Gurpurab, on religious subjects such as 'the life of Guru Nanak'. He made a great contribution to my spiritual evolution. These childhood convictions in the Gur Baani or the holy scriptures, and Rehatnama, the code of life for the Sikhs, played a great role in my understanding of the value of being a 'warrior for the cause'.